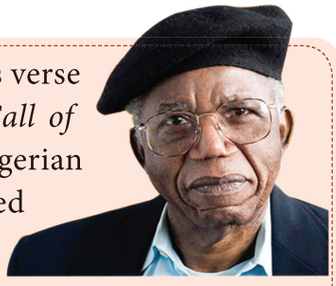
But believe me, son
I want to be what I used to be
When I was like you. I want
To unlearn all these muting things
Most of all, I want to relearn
How to laugh, for my laugh in the mirror
Shows only my teeth like a snake's bare **fangs!**

So show me, son
How to laugh; show me how
I used to laugh and smile
Once upon a time when I was like you.

About the Author



Gabriel Okara (born 1921) is a Nigerian poet and novelist. His verse has been translated into several languages. His poem *The Call of the River Nun* won the best award for Literature at the Nigerian Festival of Arts in 1953. Some of his poems were published in the influential periodical Black Orpheus, and by 1960 he established himself as an accomplished writer. He was honoured with the Commonwealth Poetry Award. Okara's typical poem transits from everyday reality to moments of delight and moves back to reality, making a complete circle. Okara infused African thought, folklore, and imagery into both his verse and prose. His first novel, *The Voice,* is an outstanding linguistic experiment. His later works include a collection of poems *The Fisherman's Invocation* (1978) and two books for children, *Little Snake and Little Frog* (1981) and *An Adventure to Juju Island* (1992).

Glossary

- **laugh with their teeth :** to fake a laugh, laugh without associated emotions
- **ice-block-cold eyes :** eyes lacking a feeling of warmth or endearing expression
- **search behind my shadow :** people are hypocritical and they don't mean what they say
- **While their left hands search my empty pockets :** evaluating the narrator's worth and power or calculating how he could be exploited
- **cocktail face :** face showing mixed emotions
- **conforming smiles like a fixed portrait smile :** wearing a standard deceitful artificial smile on all occasions
- **good-riddance :** expression of relief at being free of an unwanted person
- **fangs :** teeth of a venomous snake, used to inject poison

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